

The Mainstreaming of Marx: Measuring the Effect of the Russian Revolution on Karl Marx's Influence

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Based on Magness and Makovi (2023)

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Motivation: Two Questions

Why this paper is interesting

- ① Do political events and historical shocks change which thinkers enter mainstream academic discussion?
 - ② More specifically: did the Russian Revolution help Karl Marx become more visible than he otherwise would have been?
- ▶ This is not only about whether Marx was “right” or “wrong.”
 - ▶ It is about the sociology of ideas: attention, prestige, translation, institutions, and perceived relevance.
 - ▶ The empirical question is counterfactual: what would mentions of Marx have looked like after 1917 without the Bolshevik Revolution?

Source: Magness and Makovi (2023a); replication package Magness and Makovi (2023b).

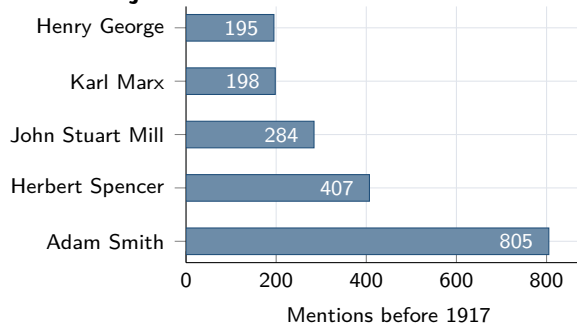
Quick Historical Introduction

Marx before 1917

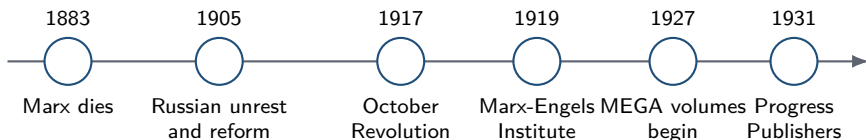
- ▶ Karl Marx (1818–1883): philosopher, economist, socialist theorist, critic of capitalism.
- ▶ By the early twentieth century, many economists viewed Marxian economics as superseded by marginalism and criticized by the transformation problem.
- ▶ Marx was influential inside socialist politics, but he was only one figure among many socialist and reformist traditions.

Source: Authors' pre-treatment journal-search counts reported in Magness and Makovi (2023a).

Pre-1917 journal mentions



October 1917 as a Shock to Attention



- ▶ The Bolshevik seizure of power made Marxism a governing ideology, not only a doctrine in socialist debates.
- ▶ Western academics, journalists, and policymakers had a new reason to read Marx: understanding Soviet Russia.
- ▶ Soviet institutions also lowered access costs by publishing, editing, translating, and circulating Marx and Engels.

Source: Magness and Makovi (2023a); historical background discussed in the paper's literature review.

Outcome Data: Google Ngrams

What is measured?

- ▶ Annual frequency of name strings in digitized books.
- ▶ Main outcome: English-language mentions of “Karl Marx.”
- ▶ The series is normalized by total words in the corpus, so it measures relative textual frequency.

How to read it

- ▶ Visibility, not endorsement.
- ▶ Books, not all academic conversation.
- ▶ Name strings can create measurement noise.
- ▶ This is why robustness checks matter.

Ngrams make the history quantifiable: they turn “Marx became more discussed” into a time series that can be compared to a counterfactual.

Synthetic Control: The Counterfactual

Intuition

- ▶ We cannot observe Marx's post-1917 visibility in a world without the Revolution.
- ▶ Synthetic control builds a weighted average of other thinkers that best matches Marx before 1917.
- ▶ After 1917, the gap between actual Marx and synthetic Marx is interpreted as the treatment effect.

Estimator

$$Y_t^{\text{synth}} = \sum_{j=1}^J w_j Y_{jt}$$

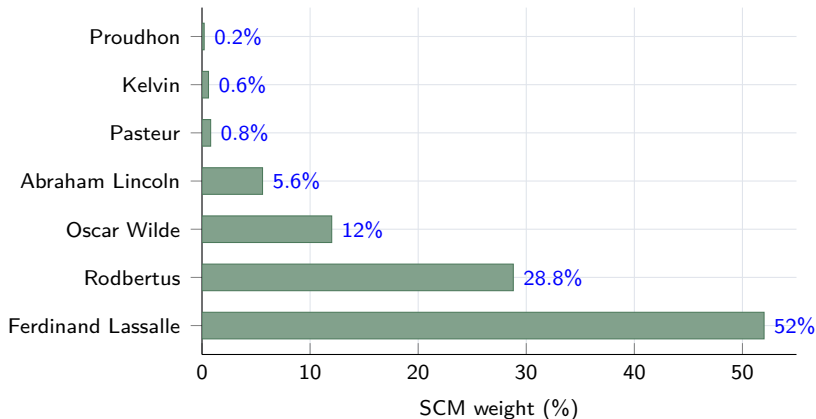
$$w_j \geq 0, \quad \sum_{j=1}^J w_j = 1$$

$$\hat{\tau}_t = Y_t^{\text{Marx}} - Y_t^{\text{synth}}, \quad t \geq 1917.$$

Design goal: match the pre-1917 trajectory, then let the post-1917 data speak.

Source: Synthetic control logic follows Abadie et al. (2010); application follows Magness and Makovi (2023a).

Who Becomes Synthetic Marx?

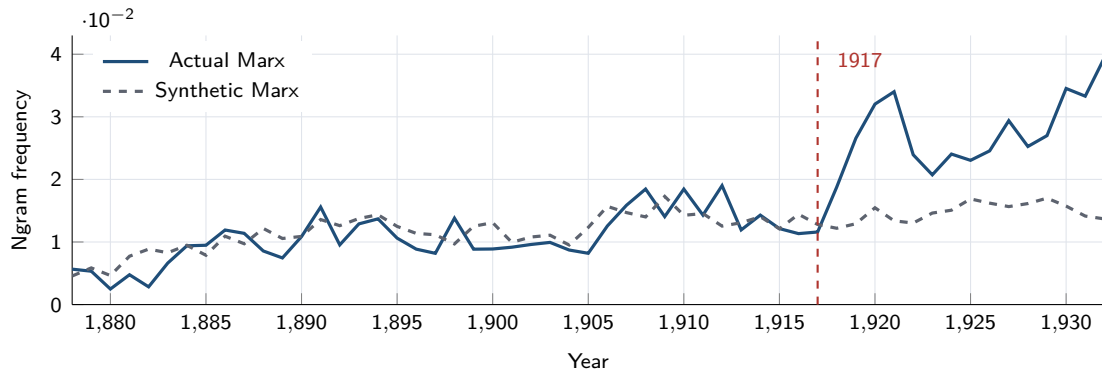


Interpretation

- ▶ The synthetic comparison is not a random mix of famous people.
- ▶ The largest weights go to socialist or socialist-adjacent figures.
- ▶ About 93% of the weight comes from socialist comparators.

Source: Weights from Table 3 in Magness and Makovi (2023a).

Main English Ngram Result



- ▶ Pre-1917: actual Marx and synthetic Marx move closely together.
- ▶ Post-1917: actual Marx rises sharply; the synthetic series stays much flatter.
- ▶ Joint post-treatment standardized placebo p-value: 0.047.

Source: English Ngram SCM estimates in Magness and Makovi (2023a); values from replication workbook.

Robustness Checks

Check	Main statistic	Reading
English Ngrams, baseline	$p = 0.047$	Marx rises more than placebo controls after 1917.
Newspapers.com replication	$p = 0.000$	Press attention shows a similar post-1917 break.
In-time placebo: 1889	$p = 0.280$	No comparable false break before the Revolution.
German Ngrams through 1932	$p = 0.069$	Similar but weaker; later German data are confounded by Nazi suppression.
German authors only	$p = 0.062$	Similar pattern in German-authored corpus.
French Ngrams	$p = 0.605$	No clear effect; older French socialist traditions may diffuse the Marx-specific shock.
Name and level tests	Similar direction	Results are not driven only by using "Karl Marx" rather than "Marx."

Bottom line

The English result survives several checks, but it is not universal across every language corpus.

Source: Robustness exercises reported in Magness and Makovi (2023a).

What the evidence supports

- ▶ A large post-1917 increase in English-language mentions of Marx.
- ▶ A plausible mechanism: political shock plus Soviet institutional amplification.
- ▶ Marx becomes more central relative to similar socialist and intellectual comparators.

What it does not prove

- ▶ That Marx was unknown or irrelevant before 1917.
- ▶ That the Revolution is the only reason Marx mattered in the twentieth century.
- ▶ That because of revolution Marx was much, much, much more popular.

- Abadie, A., Diamond, A., and Hainmueller, J. (2010). Synthetic control methods for comparative case studies: Estimating the effect of california's tobacco control program. *Journal of the American Statistical Association*, 105(490):493–505.
- Magness, P. W. and Makovi, M. (2023a). The mainstreaming of marx: Measuring the effect of the russian revolution on karl marx's influence. *Journal of Political Economy*.
- Magness, P. W. and Makovi, M. (2023b). Replication data for: The mainstreaming of marx: Measuring the effect of the russian revolution on karl marx's influence.